

Connect -- Product Write-up

Version: 0.1 (planning)

Owner: Tom Malter / Ungleicch

Linear: <https://linear.app/gorkbot/project/connect-2264dc8e786f>

Repo: <https://github.com/ungleicch/connect>

1. One-liner

Connect pairs you with a random person somewhere in the world each day for a text-only conversation. You know their country and optional taste signals (favorite book, music, movie). After about a day you can exchange socials and keep talking--or walk away with a cultural spark you would not have found otherwise.

2. Problem & insight

Cross-border friendship is usually filtered by language apps, dating apps, or algorithmically similar social graphs. There is little room for a low-stakes, time-boxed, text-first encounter with someone you would never meet--without photos, status games, or infinite scroll.

Connect is deliberately not a dating app: no profiles-as-ads, no swipes, no image-first first impression. The scarce resource is attention for one day.

3. Product principles

1. Text only -- no images, voice, video, or files in-chat (v1).
2. Scarce identity -- country (+ optional tastes); no real name required.
3. Time-boxed -- ~24h match window; continuation is an explicit choice.
4. Pause is first-class -- opt out for a period without losing the account.
5. Culture over content -- books/music/movies as bridges, not content feeds.
6. Reuse trust infrastructure -- prefer Telegram (or similar) for delivery and spam tooling rather than reinventing chat.

4. Core user journey (MVP)

1. Onboard via Telegram bot / Mini App (or chosen transport); confirm country; optionally set tastes.
2. Daily match -- at a local-friendly time (or UTC batch), receive today's partner: country + tastes.
3. Chat text-only for ~24 hours; optional AI translation (original always available).
4. End of day -- prompt: exchange social handles or close and keep the cultural tip (book/song/movie).
5. Pause anytime -- skip matching for N days/weeks.

5. Feature catalog (with difficulty)

Difficulty scale used in Linear labels: Easy - Medium - Hard - Very Hard.

5.1 Matching & identity

Feature | Diff | Notes

Country capture + display | Easy | IP geo + manual override; only country shown to partner

Fav book / music / movie fields | Easy | Normalize strings for theme-day equality

Profile + tastes data model | Medium | Pause flag, sub entitlement, match-history exclusions

Daily random matching engine | Hard | Fair pairing, timezones, exclusions, odd-one-out handling
Daily match notification | Easy | Push via Telegram with deep link
Pause / opt-out periods | Easy | Resume cleanly; no match while paused
Theme days (same book or song) | Medium | Scheduled matcher mode
Report & block | Medium | Exclude from future matches; mod queue

5.2 Chat & transport

Feature | Diff | Notes
Messaging architecture decision | Medium | Telegram-first vs custom vs Matrix
Telegram bot transport scaffold | Hard | Webhooks, privacy mode, media rejection
24h text-only session lifecycle | Hard | Open/close, reminders, soft close
Enforce text-only (no media/calls) | Medium | Reject stickers/files/voice
Social exchange opt-in | Medium | Mutual consent to share handles

5.3 Translation

Feature | Diff | Notes
Choose translation API provider | Easy | DeepL vs Google vs OpenAI; cost/latency/privacy
Translation API service wrapper | Medium | Detect, translate, cache, rate-limit, meter
In-chat translate UX | Medium | Tap or /translate; show original + translation
AI in-chat translation (epic) | Medium | End-to-end demo in matched chat

5.4 Safety & trust

Feature | Diff | Notes
Safety / spam / harmful-content approach | Hard | Policy + platform reliance + Connect controls
Harmful-text AI triage queue | Hard | Classifier + human review; false-positive tuning
Rate limits & abuse prevention | Hard (part of safety) | Per-user message caps; velocity checks

5.5 Engagement & monetization

Feature | Diff | Notes
Conversationalist ranking | Hard | Anti-gaming design; peer quality signals
\$2.99/mo country preference perk | Hard | Entitlement checked by matcher
Stripe billing + entitlements | Hard | Checkout, webhooks, subscription state

6. Matching rules (draft)

Default daily mode

- Pool: users with pause off and profile complete enough (country required).
- Pair randomly worldwide.
- Exclude: blocked pairs, recent partners (e.g. last 90 days), same-user.
- Reveal: country + optional tastes only.

Theme days

- Prefer/require shared favorite book or song (configurable).
- Fallback to random if pool too thin; log fallback rate.

Paid country preference

- Subscribers may set preferred partner country for next match.
- Soft preference (boost) vs hard filter -- product decision; hard filter can leave users unmatched.

Odd counts

- Hold one user for next batch or allow a "bye" with a short cultural prompt (no partner).

7. System architecture (sketch)

```

[Telegram users]
  |
  v
[Telegram Bot API / Mini App] <-- delivery, basic spam tools
  |
  v
[Connect Gateway]
|-- Auth / identity link (Telegram user id)
|-- Profile service (country, tastes, pause, sub)
|-- Matcher (daily jobs + theme modes)
|-- Session service (24h windows, social-exchange state)
|-- Translation service (provider wrapper + cache)
|-- Safety (report/block, triage queue)
|-- Billing (Stripe webhooks -> entitlements)
'-- Analytics (reply rates, reports, paid conversion)

```

Data principles

- Minimize PII; store social handles only after mutual exchange.
- Chat content: prefer leaving messages on Telegram where possible; if mirrored, encrypt at rest and short retention.
- Taste strings stored normalized for matching; original display form kept.

8. Translation design

1. Provider pick -- DeepL (quality), Google (coverage), OpenAI (flexible). Primary + fallback.
2. Service -- detect(text), translate(text, target_lang), cache by hash+lang, per-user RPM/daily caps, cost ledger.
3. UX -- default: on-demand translate; optional auto-translate for subscribers later.
4. Privacy -- strip identifiers before send; do not log full message bodies in analytics.
5. Failure -- show original + "translation unavailable"; never block chat on translator downtime.

9. Monetization

\$2.99 / month (working price)

- Perk v1: choose preferred country for next day's match.
- Future perks: extra theme-day eligibility, ranking badge, higher translation caps.

Free tier must remain fully usable for daily random matches so the product stays discovery-first.

10. Ranking (later)

Goal: surface great conversationalists without turning into toxicity or popularity contests.

Candidate signals

- Mutual "good conversation" votes after day end
- Low report rate
- Reply latency / completion (careful: cultural norms differ)

Anti-patterns

- Public leaderboard farming
- Ranking tied to paid status

Ship as design + stub after MVP chat works.

11. MVP scope (ship order)

M0 -- Product & architecture

- PRD freeze, Telegram-first decision, safety approach, bot scaffold

M1 -- Core matching & chat

- Profiles, country, tastes, pause, daily matcher, 24h sessions, text-only, translate MVP, report/block, notifications, social-exchange opt-in

M2 -- Engagement & monetization

- Theme days, Stripe + country perk, ranking design

12. Success metrics

- Day-1 reply rate (matched pairs with ≥ 1 message each)
- 24h completion without report
- Social-exchange opt-in rate
- Pause/resume retention
- Paid conversion (if launched)
- Translation usage vs cost

13. Risks & open questions

Risk / question | Mitigation / decision needed

Telegram ToS / bot limits | Mini App vs bot-only; review ToS before build

Unmatched hard country filters | Prefer soft boost

Translation cost at scale | Caching + caps + paid higher limits

Abuse / grooming / spam | Text-only + platform tools + report + triage

Thin theme-day pools | Fallback + larger windows

Ranking gaming | Delay ranking; private metrics first

14. Linear issue index (snapshot)

UNG-5 PRD - UNG-6 messaging decision - UNG-7 safety - UNG-8 profile model - UNG-9 matcher - UNG-10 24h session - UNG-11 translation epic - UNG-12 pause - UNG-13 social exchange - UNG-14 theme days - UNG-15 subscription - UNG-16 ranking - UNG-17 provider pick - UNG-18 translate UX - UNG-19 translation wrapper - UNG-20 country - UNG-21 tastes - UNG-22 Telegram scaffold - UNG-23 report/block - UNG-24 text-only enforce - UNG-25 match notify - UNG-26 Stripe - UNG-27 AI triage

(See Linear for live status and labels.)

15. Next concrete steps

1. Lock Telegram-first (or not) in UNG-6.
2. Pick translation provider (UNG-17) and stub wrapper (UNG-19).
3. Stand up private repo scaffolding + bot hello-world (UNG-22).
4. Spec matcher job inputs/outputs (UNG-9) against profile schema (UNG-8).